THE THEORY LAB · START HERE

Most research training teaches technique.

How to design a study. How to run the analysis. How to format the submission.

Far less of it teaches the intellectual architecture underneath.

WHY THIS EXISTS

Researchers deserve the foundations, not only the techniques.

The Theory Lab emerged from a simple but important conviction: meaningful research requires more than mastering methods; it requires understanding the philosophy, reasoning and theory that underpin the creation of knowledge.

Davis. Whetten. Bacharach. Weick. Mintzberg. DiMaggio. Alvesson and Sandberg.

Alongside them: decades of AMJ and AMR editorials in which editors say plainly what they are looking for.

THE PROBLEM

It is scattered.

Different papers. Different journals. Different decades. Different intellectual traditions.

Very little of it is read together.

Read together, across five decades, these scholars and editors keep returning to the same four challenges, not making identical arguments, but circling the same difficulties.

Four challenges, our reading, not a settled framework

1 Establish why the problem matters: a gap is not a reason

2 Develop a defensible explanatory argument, logic, not citation

3 Position novelty appropriately, calibrate the challenge

4 Make it recognisable to a reader who is not you

Two posts a week. Twenty-four weeks.

TUESDAYS · THE EDITOR'S DESK

What editors have actually written, about topic choice, introductions, hypotheses, methods, and why papers are stopped before review.

The practical problem, as an editor states it.

SATURDAYS · THE THEORY LAB

The seminal scholarship on theory itself, what it is, what it is not, and how contributions are judged.

The intellectual foundation underneath.

FOUR COMMITMENTS

Hold me to these.

1 Every post names a real source, with a full reference, so you can read it yourself.

2 Every example is typed, documented, contested, or constructed to illustrate. Those are different things.

3 Where the scholarship disagrees, you will see the disagreement, not a tidy summary.

4 Where a paper is dated, overstated or wrong, I will say so.

A QUESTION TO BEGIN WITH

When someone tells you your work needs a stronger theoretical contribution, what do you understand them to mean?

First post Tuesday: an editor's list of the ten reasons a paper never reaches a reviewer.

Not one of them is about whether the idea is any good.

Tell me in the comments

THE FOUNDATIONS, NOT JUST THE TECHNIQUES